

TO IMMORTALITY AND BEYOND

Our quest to harness the good things about technology to counter its negatives on our health and well-being doesn't just stop at buying new fitness trackers or planning out a health regimen on your smartphone. Far from it. Humanity's in this for the long haul, and has its eyes firmly set on discovering the elixir of life and unlocking physical immortality. Here's some of the steps to prolonging our health to a whole new level.

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Remember Dr. Curt Connors from The Amazing Spider Man? A scientific genius, mad beyond belief, who tries to re-engineer humans to become virtually immortal. He says, "I spent my life as a scientist trying to create a world without weakness, without outcasts. I sought to create a stronger human being, but there's no such thing. Human beings are weak, pathetic, feeble-minded creatures. Why be a human at all when we can be so much more? Faster, stronger, smarter."

Regeneration

Turns out Dr. Connors' wish could be closer to reality than we think – obviously with a far less dramatic effect. We aren't far from the day when humanity

will get past the physical limitations of our bodies, either by fixing it beyond any damage, much like lizards that heal their epidermis. Research into undying jellyfish with regenerative cells is helping scientists understand how to make the body last longer than its shelf life. Hydra, a jellyfish species, repairs almost all its cells and regenerates periodically, without aging. James Vaupel, Director, Laboratory of Survival and Longevity at the Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research in Rostock, Germany, claims it's a fundamentally different survival strategy than humans. In an interview to the BBC, Vaupel explains, "Hydras allocate resources primarily toward repair. Humans, by contrast, primarily direct resources toward reproduc-

tion, it's a different survival strategy at a species level." This only means that we can't self-heal without outside help. He also believes that senescence or biological aging can be slowed down rapidly in humans and gives a 50 per cent chance of close to negligible aging becoming a reality in our lifetime.

But if all cells "rust from oxygen exposure" and are going to suffer from inevitable destruction, however delayed it may be, what could be the next best thing than harnessing the phenomenon of 3D printing to print your tissues and organs and theoretically continue to exist forever?

Scientists have succeeded in achieving some amazing breakthroughs recently. Tissue engineering research has led to printing out a fully beating, three-dimen-

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